

AMC 10 Crash Course • Block 5 • Strategy

Cheat sheet: scoring protocol, timing plan, skip rule, mock schedule.

S.1 • The strategy lesson (90 minutes)

THE SCORING PROTOCOL

A correct answer is worth **6 points**, a blank **1.5**, a wrong answer **0**. Everything else follows from this: a blank is not a defeat, it is an asset. $25 \text{ problems} \times 6 = 150$; the course's minimum goal ($\approx 100+$) is reached like this: work 1–18 allowing two slips, and leave 19–25 blank — $16 \text{ correct} \cdot 6 + 7 \text{ blanks} \cdot 1.5 = 106.5$.

THE 75-MINUTE TIMING PLAN

25 minutes for problems 1–10 • **30 minutes** for 11–20 • **20 minutes** for your picks from 21–25.

The first ten must come cheap: if a problem from 1–10 has taken more than three minutes, you are solving it the wrong way. In 21–25 you do not “go in order”: read all five, pick the one or two where you can see a path.

THE SKIP-OR-GUESS RULE

A blind guess is worth $6/5 = 1.2$ points on average — **less** than the 1.5 for a blank. So: eliminated nothing — leave it blank. Eliminated two choices — the expected value of a guess is 2 points, now it pays. The line is simple: **guess only after honestly eliminating at least two choices**.

WORDING TRAPS

Before marking an answer, reread the question: do they ask for x or y ? the sum or the product? “what is” or “what CANNOT be”? On the AMC the wrong quantity is almost always among the choices. The habit costs five seconds and earns six points per test.

TEST-DAY CHECKLIST

Sleep; there is no calculator — and none is needed; label scratch work by problem number; transfer answers to the sheet in blocks of five; the last 3 minutes are for transfer and bubble checking only, not solving.

Four full mocks

The mocks are real past AMC 10 tests (freely published on the AoPS wiki), not homemade ones: the difficulty and phrasing calibration must be authentic. Each mock is 75 minutes under the real protocol plus a review; **a mock without a review does not count** — the review is half the value.

MOCK	WHEN	WHAT
Mock 1	week 9, after S.1	75 min + 60 review. First calibration: a loss map — where points die of not knowing vs. of rushing.
Mock 2	week 10	75 min + 60 review. Compare against Mock 1; catch-up lessons on the failed topics.
Mock 3	week 10	75 min + 60 review. Timing drill: strict 25/30/20.
Mock 4	4–5 days before 10A	Dress rehearsal: a light day, real protocol, 45-minute review. Nothing new is learned after it.

Between mocks: targeted catch-up lessons on failed topics (≈ 2 hours of reserve is built into the reviews). Review order: first the problems where the answer was close (rushing, arithmetic, misreading), then the one or two topics where the failure is systematic.

RUNNING A MOCK: THE PARENT PROTOCOL

Where to get the test. Every past AMC 10 with solutions is freely published on the AoPS wiki: artofproblemsolving.com $\rightarrow$ [AMC 10 Problems and Solutions](#). For the four mocks take recent years in order: 2024 10A, 2024 10B, 2025 10A, 2025 10B (do not open the solutions page until the review is done).

Running it. Print the problems (or open them on a separate screen), hand over scratch paper and an answer sheet numbered 1–25. A visible 75-minute timer; no phone or calculator on the desk. No hints and no commentary during the test — not even a look. When the timer sounds: pens down, sheet handed in.

Scoring. Check against the key on the same wiki page: correct $\times 6$, blank $\times 1.5$, wrong $\times 0$. Write down three numbers (correct / blank / wrong) and the total — they show the trend from mock to mock. The review happens the next day, by the rule above.

The two-version strategy: 10A and 10B

Register for both versions: **10A — Thursday, November 5, 10B — Friday, November 13**. Play 10A as the first live run: getting used to the room, the protocol, and the nerves. 10B is the main attempt: the format is familiar, and the week between the versions is spent on targeted catch-up based on A. The better score counts, so the first version risks nothing.